

MOUTH AND THROAT

DIGESTION STARTS AT THE MOUTH WHERE FOOD IS CHEWED, LUBRICATED WITH SALIVA, TURNED INTO A SOFT, MOIST MASS CALLED A BOLUS, AND SWALLOWED.

ANATOMY OF THE MOUTH AND THROAT

The interior of the lips, cheeks, and oral cavity is lined with a tough, firmly anchored mucous membrane and a type of tissue called non-keratinized squamous epithelium. Cells here multiply rapidly to replace those rubbed away when biting, chewing, and swallowing. The front underside of the tongue has a fleshy central ridge, the frenulum, which connects to the floor of the mouth. The tongue is the body's most flexible muscle. Within it are three pairs of intrinsic muscles; and outside, three pairs of extrinsic muscles run from the tongue to other parts of the throat and neck. The root of the tongue anchors to the lower jaw (mandible) and to the curved hyoid bone in the neck. The rear of the mouth leads to the middle part of the throat, the oropharynx. The whole throat or pharynx, from its nasal to laryngeal regions, is about 13cm (5in) long in a typical adult.

NOSE, MOUTH, AND THROAT

The roof of the mouth, or oral cavity, is formed by shelves of the maxillary and palatine bones of the skull (see p.49), together known as the hard palate. This extends rearward as the soft palate, which contains skeletal muscle fibres that allow it to flex when swallowing. The central posterior part of the soft palate extends into a small "finger", the uvula, which can be seen through the open mouth, dangling down from the back, where it helps to direct food downward.

